

FASHION ICON

EDWARD VIII

△ **STYLISH SUITING**

This photograph from around 1936, the year of Edward's abdication, shows him in a draped suit with notched lapel, a tabbed shirt collar, and a boldly patterned handkerchief in his breast pocket.

▷ **GOLFING GEAR**

This iconic portrait, painted by William Orpen in 1927, highlights Edward's famed love of Fair Isle sweaters and large plus fours, which helped to bring casual sportswear into everyday dress.

Edward VIII's reign as British monarch may have been brief, but he left a lasting imprint as a fashion icon. After abdicating in 1936 to marry US divorcée Wallis Simpson, the Duke of Windsor became one of the international leaders in men's fashion and was largely responsible for the rise of casual menswear in the 1930s.

Dressing down

Charming, youthful, good-looking, and with a slight frame, the blond prince was an ideal model for a revolution in tailoring. The early 1930s saw the introduction of a new style of suit that became known as the "English drape", characterized by a loose-fitting cut in the jacket, with a full chest and a defined waist. This relaxed style was promoted by Savile Row tailor, Anderson & Sheppard, and Edward soon adopted this less stuffy approach. Many of Anderson & Sheppard's other high-profile clients, such as Fred Astaire and Gary Cooper, emulated the prince's style by sporting the pioneering casual look he popularized.

Edward's promotion of casual style also led to the rise of lounge suits, which increasingly superseded more formal attire from the 1920s. By the 1940s a sweater was often worn in place of a waistcoat. The Fair Isle sweater, previously worn only as sportswear, was widely adopted as casual wear. He also helped to promote wearing plus fours off the golf course.

Among Edward's other style statements were tweed sports jackets; low, two-tone or brown suede shoes; chalk-striped wool fabrics; bold patterns and colours – such as checked and plaid suits (including the Prince of Wales check); and belts rather than braces, a practice drawn from American style.

Colours, collars, and cuffs

Edward's trend-setting role extended to eveningwear. His casual style included wearing double-breasted tuxedo-style jackets rather than tailcoats. His love of midnight-blue eveningwear also caught on, while other jacket favourites included longer hems, and lapels that extended all the way down to the bottom buttons; he preferred four buttons to the usual six.

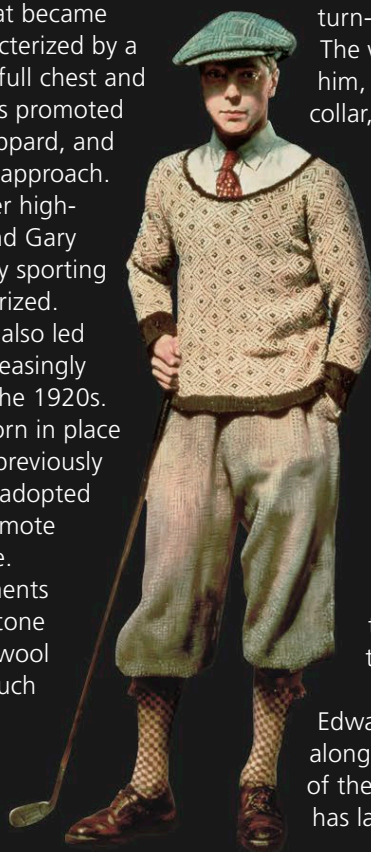
Edward is further credited with having popularized a number of details in men's formal attire, such as tab collars, non-stiffened shirt cuffs for eveningwear, turn-ups on trousers, soft collars, and striped ties. The wide "Windsor" tie knot was named after him, as was the "Prince of Wales" or "Windsor" collar, widely cut to accommodate the knot.

The face of men's fashion

Edward's impact on men's fashion spread well beyond his contemporaries. His checked and plaid suits were a likely influence on the post-war American fashions for plaid sports coats and checked shirts.

More recently, designers such as Tom Ford have been inspired by his elegance and admiration for tailoring. Other innovators emulate the way in which Edward subverted and adapted traditional styles: Hedi Slimane's emphasis on a slender silhouette, Lucas Ossendrijver's loose-fitting suits, and Thom Browne's conscious revival of 1930s style through bold prints and cropped trousers, to name just a few.

More than any other factor, however, it was Edward's questioning of conventions of male dress, along with his desire to adapt clothes to the needs of the wearer, that left a mark on men's fashion that has lasted from the 1920s to the present day.



TIMELINE

1911 Invested as Prince of Wales at Caernarfon Castle

1914 Begins his service in the army at the start of World War I

1918 Returns home at the end of World War I

▷ **1923** Cuts a dash in riding outfit with double-breasted coat and leather boots

1936 Ascends the throne as King Edward VIII in January. Abdicates in December the same year

1931 Meets Wallis Simpson for the first time at the house of Lady Furness

1937 Marries twice-divorced American Wallis Simpson

1940 Installed as Governor of the Bahamas, a post he holds for five years

1945 Wallis and Edward return to Europe

1957 Gives a heart-shaped Cartier brooch with the couple's initials engraved on it to Wallis on their 20th wedding anniversary

▷ **1960** Publishes his book, *A Family Album*, charting the changes in royal life and fashions through history

